

« Athletes have regressed. They make less money now than we did in the 1990s. They have less power and less control »

CARL LEWIS

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Things didn't go so well for Carl Lewis the last time he was at New Delhi's Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium. Lewis is one of the all-time greats of track and field, with nine Olympic and eight World Championships gold medals. But, during his only competitive appearance in India, at the Nehru Centenary International Athletic Meet in 1989, the jet-lagged American was beaten in the 100m by a little-known Austrian sprinter, Andreas Burger.

His return to the venue earlier this month, as chief guest of the Vedanta New Delhi Half Marathon, was far less stressful. Although the early morning start typical of distance running initially threw him off, Lewis soon hit his stride in a freewheeling chat with *Sportstar*.

He spoke not only about his previous experience running in India but also about how social media has distorted goals for younger athletes today, his coaching career, the one ambition he never achieved, whether track and field can reclaim the

spotlight, and how his life could come full circle at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

What was your experience at the half-marathon like?

It was really interesting because I've never been to a race at five o'clock in the morning. That was a challenge! Distance runners run in the morning all the time. Sprinters do not. We cannot! But it was a joy to see the crowds stretching endlessly and to see the happiness in people, especially the young ones.

You don't have the best memories at JLN, though. A long time ago, you competed here, and the race didn't go so well for you.

I remember it was late in the year, but yes, it happened. 1989 was kind of in the middle of my career. I didn't win every race, but I always tried to make sure I won the big ones. I don't have any sadness about that time. It was an incredible experience to come to India.

After the race, I went and bought

this huge bronze sculpture of a religious figure that I tried to take home. Unfortunately, it wouldn't fit in my luggage, so I placed it on the seat next to mine on the flight home. They even had to buckle it in! I've been to India many times. I love the country and the culture, and I'm just glad I was invited in the first place.

How did you process those moments when you did lose? Because there can't have been many of them.

I wouldn't say 'processing' is the right word. I'd say I evaluated my race. I'd look at what I could do better and ask myself a few questions: What did I do poorly? What mistakes did I make that I could correct? How did I prepare? I always evaluated my races from more of a business standpoint, not an emotional one.

I never gave away emotional control to my competition because that didn't help. I was always focused on what I could control. That meant thinking to myself, '*You didn't push out of the blocks properly, You didn't*